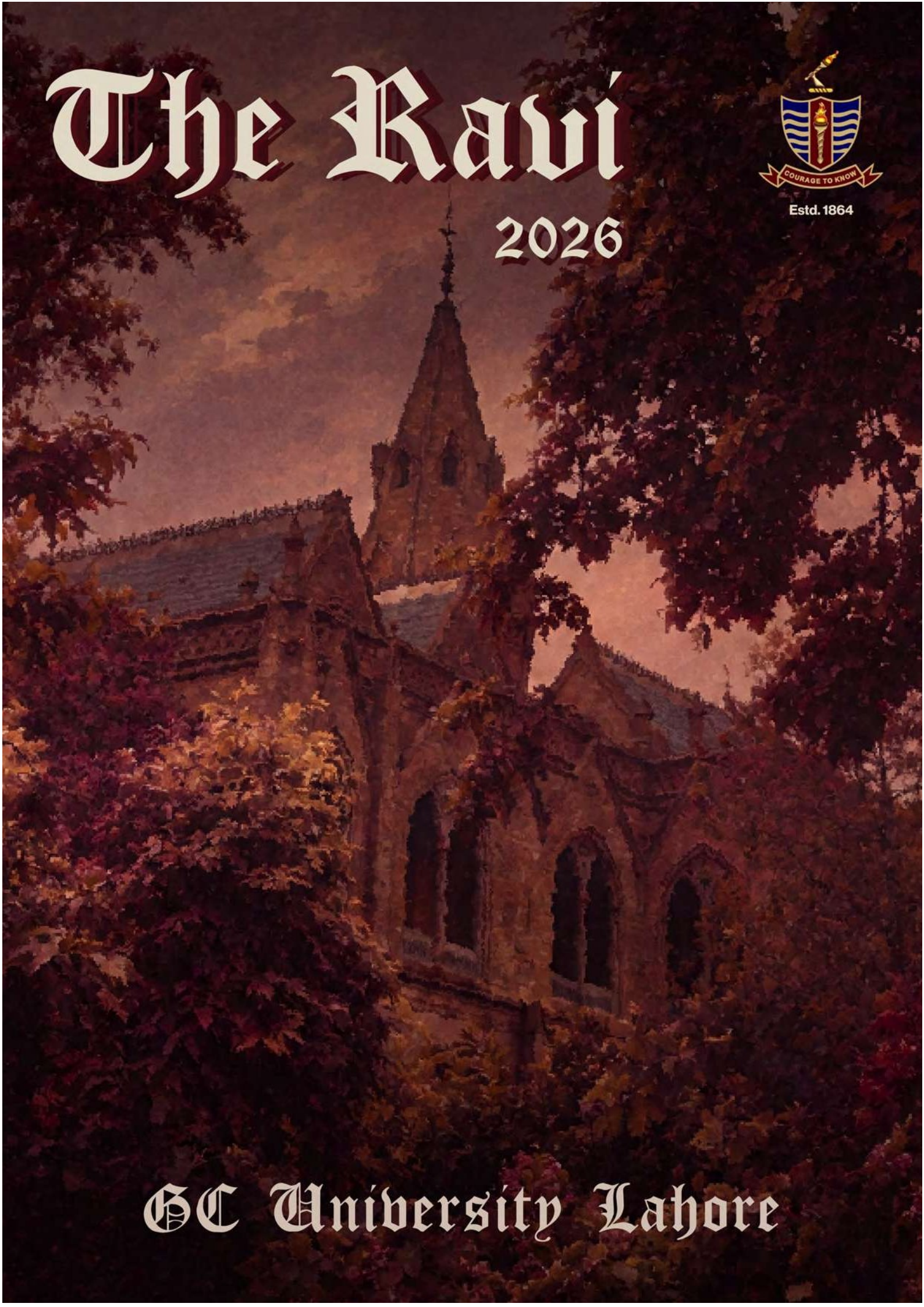
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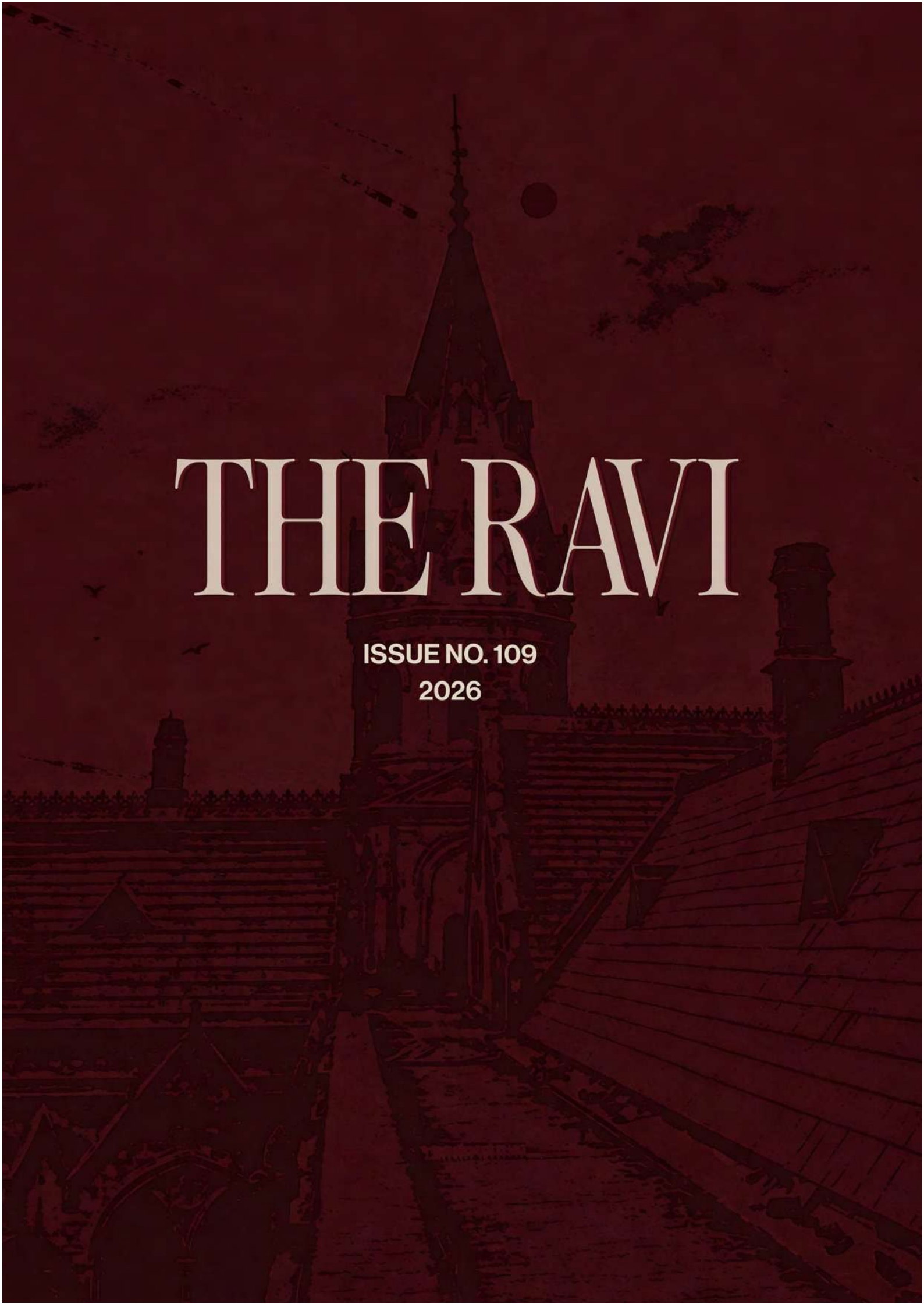
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ESSAYS

✦ Home is Another Place

- One Belongs to the Other; One Knows One Not
- Corvallis: The America That Was – and the One I Carried Home
- The Great Departure
- An Ode to Humanity's Most Faithful Companion
- Every Day is Ashura and Every Land is Karbala

Corvallis: The America That Was – and the One I Carried Home

Muhammad Usman Amin Siddiqi

Growing up in a Punjabi Sunni Muslim family in Lahore, I never questioned my place in society.

Why would I?

Everything around me – from the language spoken in the streets to the festivals we celebrated – affirmed that I belonged. I never had to consider the idea of identity, let alone reflect on my own. I didn't realize how this effortless belonging was a privilege, reinforced at every corner, classroom, and social gathering, creating a blind spot I wouldn't recognize until much later. Despite the challenges of our lower middle-class life, it felt as though hard work alone could overcome any obstacle, while I remained blissfully unaware of the deeper structural forces that quietly determined whose efforts would succeed and whose would not.

I heard the voices of those on the margins, yet I filtered their grievances through my comfortable certainty: Yes, their concerns might be legitimate, but weren't they exaggerating a bit? Weren't they missing the broader context that would explain away their struggles? I convinced myself they were viewing 'reality' through a distorted lens, one that magnified injustices while overlooking the natural order of things. The world around me felt natural, familiar, even fair, because it was built with people like me in mind – or so it seemed.

How easy it was to dismiss what I didn't have to experience.

However, that changed when I boarded a plane to Corvallis, Oregon, a journey that would lead to an education far more personal than the PhD I had come to pursue. As I prepared for my PhD, organizing research materials, revising theories, and practicing econometrics, I had no idea how completely my place in the world was about to shift. The journey across oceans wasn't just geographic. It would unsettle everything I thought I understood about belonging.

Landing in the beautiful university town of Corvallis, I was met with genuine warmth: strangers held doors open, cashiers asked about my day, and professors leaned forward with interest when I spoke. Over six years, Corvallis became a second home filled with people whose kindness became my anchor, and whom I still deeply cherish. Yet beneath that warmth, living in a new place began to stir something deeper within me, something I had never been forced to confront before.

It was the insidious realization of being an outsider.

Nothing dramatic announced this shift. There were no confrontations, no rejections, no overt hostility. Instead, it revealed itself in small, almost imperceptible moments: pausing before returning a greeting, mentally rehearsing sentences before speaking in seminars, laughing along at jokes whose context I did not understand, and nodding at references that went over my head. I noticed becoming hyper-aware of my name and where I came from whenever I introduced myself, watching for the slightest flicker of reaction. The identity I had never needed to think about now felt like a badge I could not take off.

For the first time in my life, I was on the outside looking in.

It started with a few doubts here and there. But they kept growing. What if people didn't understand me? What if they categorized me before I even had a chance to share my thoughts? What if an innocent mistake confirmed their worst assumptions? Every interaction began to feel like a performance. I weighed my words before speaking, careful not to be misunderstood. More and more, I found myself staying silent in moments when, back home, I would have spoken without a second thought.

The loneliness, too, was a new companion.

I couldn't shake the image of my five-year-old crying as I left for the airport. But it wasn't just homesickness. It was also the quiet ache of feeling out of place. Back home, I was known for my stories. Friends would lean in when I spoke. Here, those same stories fell flat, lost in translation and stripped of their cultural context. The laughter I once sparked began to disappear, and with it, so did parts of me. I found myself becoming more reserved, even boring, like a character missing all the best lines.

I was tired all the time. Drained. Even the smallest tasks felt harder.

Only later did I realize where that constant fatigue came from: having to think too hard, all the time, constantly decoding a world that did not instinctively feel like my own. My

mind seemed stuck in what Daniel Kahneman calls System 2, the slow, effortful mode of thinking.

Back home, life flowed. I moved through my days almost on autopilot, guided by instinct, by what Kahneman calls System 1. But here, nothing came naturally. Every word, gesture, and decision required conscious effort. Nothing could be taken for granted. Crossing the street meant pausing to remember which way the traffic flowed. Simple errands required mental rehearsal. Fahrenheit, miles, ounces, unfamiliar accents – everything needed translation. Even feelings. I remember sitting across from a doctor, searching for English words to describe a pain I understood so precisely in Urdu.

This wasn't just culture shock. It was cognitive exhaustion.

So yes, it was tough. But I made it through.

But not through sheer determination alone. I made it because kindness held me up when my own strength gave out. My mentors, faculty, colleagues, friends, and even strangers offered support, patience, and encouragement. Their belief in me helped me survive and, eventually, thrive. They gave me the time and space to grow into myself, not by asking me to shed my identity, but by making room for it.

No, this isn't a story of pulling myself up by the bootstraps. It's about the hands that reached out when I was too tired to stand. It wasn't the sleepless nights wrestling with calculus or the endless hours in the library that carried me through.

It was Prof. Steel checking in each morning with a one-line email: "Everything OK, Usman?"

It was Prof. Bernell making room for my family stories before turning to energy policy.

It was Prof. Boudet seeing promise in my work when I was still unsure of it myself.

It was Prof. Wolters telling me, again and again, that my writing had weight.

It was Ms. Marigold, quietly moving mountains to keep the funding steady beneath my feet.

It was neighbours checking in, strangers passing by saying, "Hey man, awesome beard," and police officers waving as they passed, making me feel seen, acknowledged, and accepted.

This isn't a motivational tale about hard work conquering adversity. It's about something far less individual and far more human: that even the strongest among us need others. I made it through because people showed up, extended grace, and made room for me when I needed it most.

I will never forget the Friday after the Christchurch mosque shootings in New Zealand. Though nearly 7,500 miles away and many hours ahead of us, the weight of that tragedy reached us in Corvallis. As I walked to the local mosque for Friday prayers that afternoon, I carried with me a strange feeling. It wasn't fear exactly, but a quiet unease I couldn't shake.

And then, I saw them.

Lining the walkway to the mosque were members of the local Corvallis community. Not Muslims, not fellow worshippers, but neighbours. Ordinary people holding flowers. They were not there to convert or intervene, only to stand with us. To look us in the eyes and say, without words:

You are safe. We see you. We are with you.

It was surprising how much it meant to simply feel safe, to be seen as you are. I couldn't stop the tears as I thought of those who had rarely, if ever, known that feeling, even in places they called home. I thought of communities back home where tragedy did not bring people together, where flowers were replaced by mobs and fires, and solidarity by silence from those who should speak and fear among those who could not.

For them, vulnerability isn't temporary, as mine was. It is a constant condition of life.

My experience was sheltered, softened by the privileges of a supportive university, caring mentors, and a welcoming town. But even that brief glimpse of vulnerability, outside the comfort of everything I had once taken for granted, cracked open the certainty I had carried for so long. It forced me to confront an uncomfortable truth: the same society that had given me an effortless sense of belonging had also conditioned me to overlook those who were systematically denied it.

Being an outsider gave me something invaluable: perspective.

Now, I hear the voices I once dismissed as overreacting differently. What once seemed exaggerated to me now reveals truths I had been too sheltered to see. I have learned to

listen with greater humility and to stand in solidarity with those pushed to the margins for any reason, whether because of race, religion, gender, class, disability, or identity.

The America I carried home isn't the one in headlines, but the one I found in Corvallis, where simple acts of kindness became my lifelines far from home. As the nation pulls away from this welcoming spirit, I hold onto this experience as both a memory and a quiet hope.

When I was invited to write for Ravi, I chose to take readers to Corvallis before eventually returning to GC University, Lahore, another place very close to my heart.

GCU admits one of the most diverse student cohorts in Pakistan every year. But diversity doesn't end at admission. That is where the real work begins. Students from the most remote corners of the country arrive here carrying the quiet burdens of displacement and difference, often with far less support than I had. Many tread the same unfamiliar paths I once did.

Let's make sure they don't have to walk those paths alone.

To do that, we must unlearn our biases and confront the structural forces that hold some people back while quietly carrying others forward.

For faculty, this means learning to recognize brilliance behind language barriers, broadening our understanding of what "appropriate" student behaviour looks like, and, most importantly, respecting the kind of education earned through survival rather than trying to correct it to fit dominant narratives. Many of these students carry worldviews forged by war, loss, displacement, or systemic neglect, realities that often remain abstract concepts to many of us who have never had to leave the safety of our hometowns. Let's be mindful not to mistake a late submission or absence for negligence. It may reflect a sacred holiday not marked on our academic calendar, a family obligation, or the exhaustion of a fifty-hour journey back home.

For students who enjoy the privilege of easy belonging, it means pausing to notice the classmate quietly searching for cues on how to fit in. Let's step beyond our usual circles, notice when our jokes unintentionally leave someone out, and allow our own assumptions to be gently challenged.

For administrators, this means designing policies, from financial aid to hostel accommodation, that ease rather than add to the burdens of difference and displacement.

We may not be able to erase every injustice, but we can offer one another a quiet certainty: that we are seen, that someone will stand beside us, and that, if only for a moment, we do not have to carry our burdens alone.

Inclusion is not charity. It is justice.

Prof. Steel once shared something his own mentor had told him: "The kindness you receive isn't meant to stop with you. Pass it on."

The author is an Old Ravian whose ties to GC University Lahore span around two decades, first as a student and later as a member of the faculty. This essay reflects on his years as a PhD scholar at Oregon State University in Corvallis, Oregon, USA, and is written in gratitude to the friends, mentors, and strangers from both sides of that journey who helped him find his place.